EMERGENCY CONTACT

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EPISODE 1: HE'S NOT MY BOYFRIEND

INT. AAROGYA HOSPITAL, WARD 3 - NIGHT

MEERA (28) opens her eyes. Her left wrist is in a fresh blue cast. She turns her head.

KARTHIK (30) is asleep in the plastic chair beside her bed, a wet helmet on his lap, studio headphones still round his neck.

JYOTHI (40s), the night nurse, checks the drip.

JYOTHI
లేచారా? మీ boyfriend రెండు గంటల నుంచి ఇక్కడే ఉన్నారు.

MEERA
(hoarse)
Nurse... అతను నా boyfriend కాదు.

JYOTHI
Okay.
(beat)
అయితే వెళ్ళిపొమ్మని చెప్పనా?

Meera looks at Karthik.

She says nothing.

A long silence.

Jyothi adjusts the drip and leaves.

Karthik stirs, sees her awake, and is instantly up.

KARTHIK
హే. Water కావాలా?

MEERA
నువ్వు ఇక్కడ ఏం చేస్తున్నావ్?

KARTHIK
(pouring water)
ముందు తాగు. తర్వాత మాట్లాడుదాం.

He holds the cup; she drinks. He cranks the bed up a notch without asking.

KARTHIK (CONT'D)
Flyover మీద scooty జారిందంట. వర్షంలో visor ఎత్తి నడిపావా?

MEERA
...లేదు.

KARTHIK
అబద్ధం.

The corner of her mouth twitches.

INT. WARD 3 - LATER

Karthik tapes her cracked phone screen with surgical tape, careful as a sound edit.

2:40 AM. Karthik dozes upright in the chair, headphones round his neck, one hand resting on the bed rail near her good hand. Not touching.

Meera watches him. Her lips part.

MEERA
(whisper)
Karthik...

He doesn't wake. She doesn't try again.

INT. WARD 3 - DAWN

Grey light. Karthik's phone buzzes on the bedside table. The screen reads "Amma calling".

He glances at Meera. Her eyes are closed. He steps to the window.

KARTHIK
(into phone)
హా అమ్మా... లేదు లేదు, నాకేం కాలేదు. Hospital లో ఉన్నా... ఒకళ్ళకి accident అయింది.

SARALA (V.O.)
ఎవరికి రా?

A beat. He looks back at the bed.

KARTHIK
(into phone)
Office లో ఒకళ్ళు, అమ్మా. Someone from work.

He hangs up. Turns.

Meera's eyes are open. She heard every word.

She looks at the ceiling. Not at him.

EPISODE 2: WHO CALLED YOU?

INT. AAROGYA HOSPITAL, WARD 3 - MORNING

A cracked phone screen, held together with surgical tape: "11 missed calls - Karthik ❤". 9:40 PM to 10:05 PM.

MEERA, one-handed, opens the contact. Edit. She deletes the heart. Save. It now reads "Karthik".

The door swings. KARTHIK enters with two paper cups of filter coffee.

KARTHIK
Canteen లో filter coffee ఉంది.
Doctor పది గంటలకి discharge అన్నారు.

MEERA
(too bright)
Thanks for coming, Karthik. Really.
Work లో వాళ్ళ కోసం ఇంత చేస్తారా ఎవరైనా?

He misses it. He hands her the cup and holds it until she has a grip.

KARTHIK
చెయ్యి ఎలా ఉంది?

MEERA
అసలు నీకెలా తెలిసింది? నేను ఇక్కడున్నానని.

KARTHIK
Hospital వాళ్ళే call చేశారు. నేను నీ
emergency contact అంట.

She stares at him.

MEERA
నేను ఎవరి పేరూ ఇవ్వలేదు.

KARTHIK
(shrugs)
అయితే ఎవరో ఇచ్చారు.

Her phone rings: "Amma". Meera straightens, swallows, and answers in her office voice.

MEERA
(into phone)
హా అమ్మా... Office లో ఉన్నా, meeting లో... అవును, తిన్నాను.

PADMA (V.O.)
ఇవాళ temple లో Arjun వాళ్ళ అమ్మ కలిశారు తెలుసా? నిన్ను బాగా అడిగారు...

Meera's face changes. Karthik notices and watches her.

MEERA
(into phone)
Okay అమ్మా, తర్వాత call చేస్తా. Bye.

She cuts the call. Karthik raises an eyebrow. She sips her coffee and avoids his eyes.

INT. AAROGYA RECEPTION - DAY

Discharge papers. Karthik signs as the attendant. JYOTHI, off shift with her coat on, hands Meera a file.

JYOTHI
ఒక్క నిమిషం madam. Emergency contact confirm చేస్తారా, change చేస్తారా?

MEERA
నేను అసలు ఎవరినీ ఇవ్వలేదు.

JYOTHI
(flipping pages)
మీ పాత file... ఏడు నెలల క్రితం, dengue admission. అప్పుడు రాశారు.

She turns the form around. EMERGENCY CONTACT: Karthik, with his number. RELATIONSHIP: Friend.

The handwriting is neat and slanted. It isn't hers.

JYOTHI (CONT'D)
మార్చాలా?

MEERA
...Later.

Then she sees the signature at the bottom of the form: "Arjun Varma".

The name her mother just said.

Her good hand tightens on the page, crumpling the corner.

EPISODE 3: THE FORM

INT. AAROGYA RECEPTION - NIGHT (SEVEN MONTHS AGO)

SUPER: "7 MONTHS AGO"

Fluorescent glare. ARJUN VARMA (31), crisp shirt, two phones, fills in a form at the counter.

Behind him, MEERA, feverish, is slumped in a wheelchair, whispering into her phone.

MEERA
(barely audible)
Karthik... నాకు భయంగా ఉంది...

Arjun's pen stops at "EMERGENCY CONTACT".

INT. AAROGYA WARD - DAWN (SEVEN MONTHS AGO)

Through the ward's glass panel, Arjun watches. KARTHIK arrives with an idli parcel and a phone charger. Meera, grey with fever, lights up.

Arjun looks down at the form. He writes a number. Slowly.

INT. KARTHIK'S CAR - DAY

SUPER: "NOW"

Rain. Wipers. Meera in the passenger seat, the folded form in her lap. Karthik hums along to a track on the stereo.

MEERA
ఇది ఎవరిది?

KARTHIK
నేనే mix చేశా. Ad jingle. Client కి నచ్చలేదు.

MEERA
నాకు నచ్చింది.

He glances at her and smiles. She almost unfolds the form. She doesn't.

INT. MEERA'S BUILDING, STAIRWELL - DAY

A paper sign on the lift reads "OUT OF ORDER". Karthik carries her bag up the stairs. She reaches for it.

MEERA
ఇవ్వు, నేను తీసుకెళ్తా.

KARTHIK
ఒక్క చేత్తోనా? నాలుగో floor కి?

MEERA
నేను ఒక్కదాన్నే manage చేసుకుంటా. ఎప్పుడూ చేసుకున్నా కదా.

KARTHIK
తెలుసు. అందుకే ఇవ్వను.

INT. MEERA'S DOORWAY - CONTINUOUS

Fourth floor. Both are breathless, standing close. Rain sounds through the stairwell grille.

MEERA
Karthik.
(beat)
నేను నీకు ఏమవుతాను?

He holds her gaze. Too long. Then he looks down at the bag as he sets it down.

KARTHIK
Rest తీసుకో. Tablets టైంకి వేసుకుంటే చాలు.

He goes down the stairs. She listens to his footsteps fade.

INT. MEERA'S FLAT - CONTINUOUS

She shuts the door and leans on it.

Her phone lights up: "Arjun".

ON SCREEN: "Accident gurinchi vinnanu. Are you okay? Can we meet?"

EPISODE 4: THE EX WHO PROPOSED

INT. KONDAPUR CAFÉ - DAY

Meera walks in, blue cast first. ARJUN is already there, standing. Before she can sit:

ARJUN
ఆ form నేనే రాశా, Meeru.

She sits, slowly.

MEERA
ఎందుకు?

She notices there are no phones on the table. He sees her notice.

ARJUN
Bag లో ఉన్నాయి. Silent లో.
(beat)
ఆ రాత్రి నీకు 103 జ్వరం. నేను నీ పక్కనే ఉన్నా. నువ్వు phone చేసింది మాత్రం వాడికి.

MEERA
నాకు గుర్తు లేదు.

ARJUN
నాకు ఉంది. పొద్దున్న ఆరింటికి వాడు వచ్చాడు. Idli తో, charger తో. నువ్వు నవ్వావ్. ఆ రెండు రోజుల్లో నా వైపు చూసి ఒక్కసారి కూడా అలా నవ్వలేదు.

Meera looks down at her coffee.

MEERA
ఏడు నెలలు నిన్నే blame చేశా. నువ్వు వెళ్ళిపోయావని.

ARJUN
నేను వెళ్ళిపోలేదు, Meeru. నువ్వు ఎప్పుడో వెళ్ళిపోయావ్. నేను ఒప్పుకున్నా, అంతే.

Silence. Behind the counter, a milk frother screams.

ARJUN (CONT'D)
నేను మారాను. నిజంగా. Calls తగ్గించా. ఒక therapist దగ్గరికి వెళ్తున్నా. వినడం నేర్చుకుంటున్నా.

He reaches for her good hand on the table and stops an inch short. He doesn't touch it.

ARJUN (CONT'D)
ఇంకోసారి try చేద్దామా? ఈసారి నేను ఉంటా.

Meera stares at her cast.

No yes. No no.

EPISODE 5: SOMEONE FROM WORK

INT. MEERA'S FLAT, FRONT DOOR - EVENING

Meera opens the door. KARTHIK stands there with two grocery bags and one mango balanced on top, already rolling up his sleeves.

KARTHIK
నీ left hand rest లో ఉంది. నా right hand duty లో ఉంది.

MEERA
(fighting a smile)
Mango ఎందుకు?

KARTHIK
Dessert.

INT. MEERA'S KITCHEN - EVENING

Karthik at the stove. Meera sits on the counter, directing one-handed.

MEERA
ఇంకొంచెం అల్లం. ...అంత కాదు!

He flips a pesarattu. It folds into a mess.

KARTHIK
Abstract pesarattu.

She laughs, for the first time since the hospital.

Her phone on the counter lights up. Karthik's eyes go to it.

ON SCREEN: "Arjun: Dinner Saturday? No pressure."

Karthik turns back to the pan.

KARTHIK (CONT'D)
(even)
నీ ఇష్టం.

Meera's laugh dies.

His right hand grips the pan handle, knuckles white. The pesarattu begins to smoke.

MEERA
మీ అమ్మకి నేను 'someone from work' నా?

Silence. The pesarattu burns. Smoke curls up.

MEERA (CONT'D)
ఆ రోజు నేను నిద్రపోలేదు, Karthik. అంతా
విన్నా.

He turns off the stove. He doesn't turn around.

KARTHIK
Late అయింది. Tablets మర్చిపోకు.

He picks up his helmet and goes. The door clicks shut.

INT. MEERA'S FLAT - NIGHT

Meera alone. The burnt pesarattu is still in the pan, the mango untouched.

She opens Arjun's chat and types one-handed: "Saturday. Okay."

Her thumb hovers. She sends it.

EPISODE 6: PRESENT TENSE

EXT. ROOFTOP RESTAURANT, JUBILEE HILLS - NIGHT

Fairy lights, the city below. ARJUN slides both his phones face-down onto the table.

ARJUN
ఈరోజు only you.

Meera, surprised, smiles.

MEERA
Wow. Therapist గారికి thanks చెప్పాలి.

ARJUN
చెప్తా.
(leaning in)
Meeru, నేను అంతా plan చేశా. మార్గశిరలో మంచి ముహూర్తం ఉంది. Kondapur లో 3BHK చూశా, నీ office కి పది నిమిషాలు. అమ్మ already మీ అమ్మతో మాట్లాడింది...

MEERA
Arjun, ఒక్క నిమిషం—

ARJUN
—నువ్వేం tension పడక్కర్లేదు, అన్నీ నేను చూసుకుంటా. Interiors కూడా నీ taste ప్రకారమే...

Under the table, Meera's wrist throbs. She winces and presses the cast to her stomach.

He doesn't notice. He's describing a balcony.

She glances at the phone in her lap. No messages. Karthik's name stays silent.

ARJUN (CONT'D)
...ఏమంటావ్?

MEERA
(caught)
హా? ...Sorry.

ARJUN
పర్లేదు.

He carries on. She checks the phone again. The fourth time.

It rings: "Karthik". She answers before the first ring ends.

MEERA
(into phone)
హలో?

KARTHIK (V.O.)
(voice breaking)
Meera... అమ్మని Warangal లో admit చేశారు. Chest pain. నాకు... నాకేం చేయాలో అర్థం కావట్లేదు.

She's already standing.

MEERA
(into phone)
నువ్వు ఎక్కడున్నావ్? ...MGBS దగ్గరే ఉండు. వస్తున్నా.

She turns to Arjun. Before she can explain, he's on his feet, keys in hand.

ARJUN
పద. నేను drop చేస్తా.

INT. ARJUN'S CAR - NIGHT

Arjun drives fast and clean through wet Hyderabad. He doesn't speak. Meera grips the door handle with her good hand.

MEERA
Thanks, Arjun.

ARJUN
(eyes on the road)
ఏడు నెలల క్రితం కూడా ఇలాగే ఉన్నావ్, Meeru.
వాడి కోసం.

EXT. MGBS BUS STAND - NIGHT

Tube lights. Buses breathing diesel. KARTHIK stands alone under a pillar, lost, a backpack hanging off one shoulder.

Meera runs to him and takes his hand.

In the car, Arjun watches through the windshield. He understands. Again.

EPISODE 7: WARANGAL

INT. OVERNIGHT BUS - NIGHT

Rain streaks the window. Karthik sits in the aisle seat, staring at nothing. His hand trembles on his knee.

Meera lays her cast over it, gently, and holds it there.

Neither speaks. The bus rocks on.

INT. WARANGAL CITY HOSPITAL, CORRIDOR - DAWN

Meera at the counter, a pharmacy bill clamped in her teeth, signing with her good hand. She talks to a DOCTOR, nods, and types notes into her phone.

Karthik sits frozen on a steel bench, holding his mother's slippers.

Meera sits beside him.

MEERA
Mild attack అంట. Stable గా ఉన్నారు. Angiogram రేపు. Medicines తెచ్చా.

KARTHIK
(barely)
నువ్వు ఎలా... ఇవన్నీ...

MEERA
నువ్వేగా నేర్పించావ్.

INT. SARALA'S ROOM - NIGHT

Karthik is asleep in the chair beside the bed, head tipped back, headphones round his neck.

SARALA (56), reading glasses on a chain, studies Meera, who sits on the edge of the visitor's cot.

SARALA
నువ్వే కదా... వాడు రాత్రి ఒంటిగంటకి
మాట్లాడేది?

MEERA
(caught)
లేదు ఆంటీ, నేను... work లో–

SARALA
రాత్రంతా bus లో, ఆ చేత్తో, ఎవరో తెలీని ఆంటీ
కోసం వచ్చే అమ్మాయి... work లో ఒకళ్ళు
కాదమ్మా.

Meera has no answer.

Sarala looks at her sleeping son.

SARALA (CONT'D)
వాళ్ళ నాన్న... ఇరవై ఏళ్ళ తర్వాత
వెళ్ళిపోయారు. ఒక bag పట్టుకుని. అప్పుడు
వీడికి పద్నాలుగేళ్ళు.
(beat)
నేను నెలల తరబడి gate దగ్గర నిలబడేదాన్ని.
వీడు చూసేవాడు. ఏమీ అనేవాడు కాదు.

MEERA
(quiet)
నాకు తెలీదు.

SARALA
వాడు ఎవరికీ చెప్పడు.
(beat)
పేరు పెడితే పోగొట్టుకుంటాం అనుకుంటాడు వాడు.
పేరు పెట్టకపోతే ఇంకా ఎక్కువ పోగొట్టుకుంటాం అని
తెలీదు.

Meera looks at Karthik as if seeing him for the first time.

INT. SARALA'S ROOM - MORNING

Karthik is awake now. A WARD NURSE holds out a clipboard.

WARD NURSE
Second emergency contact కావాలి sir.
Form complete చేయాలి.

Karthik takes the pen and writes his own name on line one.

SARALA
ఈ అమ్మాయి number రాయి, Karthik.

Karthik's pen moves to "EMERGENCY CONTACT 2".

It stops.

Meera watches. Sarala watches. The nurse waits.

The pen hovers. Karthik doesn't move.

EPISODE 8: THE PEN

INT. SARALA'S ROOM - MORNING

The uncapped pen is set down on the blank line.

KARTHIK
అవసరం లేదు, అమ్మా. నేను ఉన్నా కదా.

Sarala looks at her son for a long moment. Then she turns to Meera.

SARALA
నీ number నాకు ఇవ్వు. వాడు రాయకపోయినా,
నేను రాసుకుంటా.

Meera hesitates, then says the digits quietly. Sarala saves them on her old keypad phone, slowly, while Karthik watches.

WARD NURSE
(taking the clipboard)
Okay sir.

EXT. WARANGAL BUS STAND - DAWN

The next day. Steam rises from a tea stall. Karthik and Meera sit on a cement bench with two paper cups. A bus marked "HYDERABAD" idles, engine grumbling.

KARTHIK
Angiogram అయిపోయింది. Stent అవసరం లేదంట. Medicines చాలు.
(beat)
నువ్వు లేకపోతే నేను—

MEERA
(gently)
Karthik.

He stops.

MEERA (CONT'D)
నువ్వు భయపడినప్పుడు నన్ను పిలుస్తావ్. నేను వస్తా. ఎప్పుడూ వస్తా.
(beat)
కానీ ఎవరైనా అడిగితే... 'someone from work'.

KARTHIK
Meera, అది—

MEERA
నేను నీ emergency ని, Karthik. నీ life ని కాదు.

He opens his mouth. Nothing comes out.

The bus honks.

CONDUCTOR (O.S.)
Hyderabad! Hyderabad! బయలుదేరుతోంది!

Meera stands. She leaves her tea untouched on the bench.

MEERA
అమ్మ దగ్గర ఉండు. ఆమెకి ఇప్పుడు నువ్వు కావాలి.

She boards. She doesn't look back until she's in her seat.

INT. BUS - CONTINUOUS

Through the window, Karthik sits on the bench with two paper cups beside him, getting smaller as the bus pulls out.

Her phone rings: "Amma".

PADMA (V.O.)
Meeru! Sunday lunch కి Lakshmi గారు పిలిచారు! Arjun వాళ్ళ ఇంటికి. సరిగ్గా మాట్లాడుకుందాం అన్నారు. వస్తున్నావ్ కదా?

Meera watches the last of Karthik vanish behind a lorry.

MEERA
(into phone)
వస్తాను, అమ్మా.

EPISODE 9: NEITHER

INT. VARMA HOUSE, DINING ROOM, JUBILEE HILLS - DAY

A long table, steel tumblers. LAKSHMI VARMA (50s) sweeps in with a box of sweets and a folded paper before the rice is even served.

LAKSHMI
మార్గశిరలో మంచి ముహూర్తం ఉంది, Padma గారు! పంతులు గారు మూడు dates ఇచ్చారు!

PADMA RAO (55) beams. Then her eyes fall on Meera's arm.

PADMA
Meeru... ఇదేంటి?

MEERA
చిన్న accident అమ్మా. Scooty జారింది. ఏం కాలేదు.

PADMA
(quiet)
ఎప్పుడు?

MEERA
...రెండు వారాలైంది.

Padma says nothing more. She sets her tumbler down very carefully. The hurt is total.

ARJUN, at the head of the table, glances between them. Then his phone buzzes.

ARJUN
Sorry, ఒక్క రెండు నిమిషాలు. Client.

He takes the call right there at the table, in English: "Yes, we can push the deck to Monday..."

Lakshmi keeps reading out dates. Meera watches Arjun: the same absence, in a nicer shirt.

EXT. VARMA HOUSE, GARDEN - DAY

Bougainvillea. Arjun comes out, pocketing his phone, contrite.

ARJUN
Sorry. Last time, promise.

MEERA
Arjun. Form లో నువ్వు correct గానే చూశావ్.

He goes still.

MEERA (CONT'D)
కానీ conclusion తప్పు. నేను వాడిని పిలిచేది వాడు perfect అని కాదు. నేను ఎవరినీ ఎక్కువ అడగలేదు కాబట్టి. నిన్ను కూడా.
(beat)
లేదు, Arjun.

A long moment. He nods, with dignity.

ARJUN
(soft)
తెలుసు. ఆ రోజు café లోనే తెలుసు.

He goes inside.

PADMA is behind a pillar. She has heard everything. She walks over to Meera.

PADMA
Accident గురించి నాకు చెప్పలేదు.
(beat)
నీ మనసు గురించి నీకే చెప్పుకోలేదు.

Meera's eyes fill. Padma takes her good hand.

PADMA (CONT'D)
నీ ఇష్టం, Meeru. నిజంగా నీ ఇష్టం.

INT. MEERA'S FLAT - NIGHT

Meera on the sofa with the hospital app open: "Update emergency contact?"

She types "Amma". Her thumb hovers over SAVE.

A notification slides down over it.

ON SCREEN: "Karthik shared a folder with you: work"

She taps it. A list loads: voice notes, all in her own voice. "Meera 03-Jan 1.12am". "Meera 14-Feb 12.58am". The count at the bottom reads 214.

She presses one. Her own sleepy voice fills the room.

MEERA (V.O.)
(recorded, laughing)
...నిద్ర రావట్లేదు. ఏదైనా మాట్లాడు, Karthik.

Meera puts her hand over her mouth.

EPISODE 10: EMERGENCY CONTACT

INT. AAROGYA RECEPTION - MORNING

The blue cast lies on the counter, cut open. Meera rubs her pale, thin wrist.

JYOTHI slides a form across.

JYOTHI
Emergency contact update చేయాలా, madam?

Meera picks up the pen.

A long silence.

The entrance doors hiss open. KARTHIK, unshaven, with a backpack, straight off the Warangal bus, stops a few feet away, breathing hard.

KARTHIK
అమ్మ చెప్పింది... ఇవాళ నీ cast తీసేస్తారని.

A flicker on Meera's face. She and Sarala have been texting.

KARTHIK (CONT'D)
Meera.

Before she can answer, his phone rings: "Amma calling".

He looks at it. Looks at her. Then he presses speaker.

KARTHIK (CONT'D)
(into phone, loud enough for the whole queue)
అమ్మా. Meera తో ఉన్నా.
(beat)
Work లో కాదు. నా మనిషి.

The queue goes quiet. Jyothi stops typing.

SARALA (V.O.)
(on speaker)
తెలుసురా. ఇప్పటికి చెప్పావ్.

She hangs up.

Karthik lowers the phone and turns to Meera, unsteady.

KARTHIK
పేరు పెడితే పోతుంది అనుకున్నా. పెట్టకపోతే నువ్వే పోయావ్.

Meera doesn't run to him. She holds his gaze.

MEERA
నేను కూడా ఎప్పుడూ అడగలేదు. ఎవరినీ. అడగడానికి భయం.
(beat)
ఇప్పుడు అడుగుతున్నా.

She slides the form and pen to him.

MEERA (CONT'D)
అయితే నువ్వే రాయి. Relationship column కూడా.

He takes the pen and writes. He doesn't hesitate this time.

Then he reaches into her tote bag, takes out the cut cast, and signs the inside of it.

Her phone buzzes: "Arjun".

ON SCREEN: "Pune transfer accepted, next month nunchi. Take care, Meeru. Ee saari, evarini pilavalanukunte vaallani pilu."

Meera reads it twice. A small, sad smile. She types "Thank you, Arjun." and sends it.

JYOTHI
(dry, collecting the form)
So... boyfriend?

Meera looks at Karthik. Karthik looks at the floor, then at her.

MEERA
(smiling)
ఇంకా decide చేయలేదు.

Jyothi holds the form. In his handwriting, out of focus, the line reads "Relationship: __".

FADE OUT.